

# Race in Maine draws national concern

Allegations against candidate set back Democrats' hopes of flipping Senate seat.

By JUSTINE MCDANIEL AND IRIS KWOK

WASHINGTON — The campaign of U.S. Senate nominee Graham Platner was buckling in Maine on Tuesday after he was accused of rape, injecting uncertainty into a contest that is central to determining which party wins Senate control in November's midterms.

The situation set off swift debate about how state Democrats would choose Platner's replacement if he were to withdraw, and which Maine figures might be best positioned to play off the progressive messaging he used to win over voters.

With Maine viewed by Democrats as a key seat to win in their long-shot bid for a Senate majority, the decision would be high-stakes, analysts said. In the meantime, with uncertainty clouding the race, the shake-up could put additional pressure on the party to win Senate races in states seen as more difficult to flip.

Platner has denied the rape allegation, which came in a Politico report Monday from a woman who said Platner forced her to have sex with him when he was intoxicated. Platner said Monday that he would "reflect" on his candidacy but has not withdrawn.

"The calculation that almost everyone on the Democratic side is making is that with Platner in it, it is an unwinnable race," said John Cluverius, director of survey research for the Center for Public Opinion at UMass Lowell, "and without Platner in it, they have a much better chance."

An oyster farmer and Marine veteran, Platner had entered the race to challenge Republican Sen. Susan Collins as an outsider and was seen as riding an anti-establishment wave of support.

His candidacy highlighted the split within his party between progressives and establishment Democrats and represented a matchup between an older incumbent and a younger outsider candidate.

By Tuesday afternoon, Platner's financial backing was disintegrating and prominent Democrats had withdrawn their support — including Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vt.), a key endorser of Platner's, who said Tuesday afternoon that he had told Platner to withdraw.

A spokesperson for Platner's campaign did not immediately respond to a request for comment Tuesday.

Rep. Ro Khanna (D-Fremont), who had been one of Platner's most visible backers, quickly withdrew his endorsement Monday.

[See Maine, A6]



WIN McNAMEE/Getty Images

## ALLIES IN ANKARA

**PRESIDENTS** Trump and Recep Tayyip Erdogan of Turkey meet Tuesday in Ankara, where they are attending a NATO summit. Turkey wants to regain access to the U.S. F-35 program. **WORLD, A2**

# Hollywood bets on web content

Last month, veteran Hollywood producer Roy Lee got three calls in a single day from executives at three different studios. Each believed they had found the next internet-native short poised to become a Hollywood blockbuster — an online monster named Siren Head — and each was ready to make an offer and wanted Lee's help to develop a movie.

The frenzy traces back to the enduring global box-office runs of two low-budget horror films, Curry Barker's "Obsession" and Kane Parsons' "Backrooms," which have earned \$403 million and \$349 million, respectively. Studios have become fixated on hunting down every short film, internet meme and indie video game

Amid the box-office high of 'Obsession' and 'Backrooms,' studios look online for untapped talent and viral material

By Cerys Davies

with the potential to "put something new and fresh on the screen," Lee said.

"In the past, whenever we were putting together movies with the studios, they would resort to going back to safer bets with filmmakers who've made movies before," Lee said, whose L.A.-based horror production company, Spooky Pictures, secured three Barker films before "Obsession" hit theaters. "But because of the [ongoing] success, bosses are going to their lower-level executives saying, 'You better find the next person and bring them to us.'"

The race for Hollywood to capture new-age internet intellectual property [See Movies, A11]

# Support for Israel in the U.S. shrinking

By STEVE PEOPLES AND LINLEY SANDERS

NEW YORK — After decades of reliable bipartisan backing for Israel, a new AP-NORC poll reveals a dramatic erosion of support for the longtime U.S. ally, with rising opposition from Democrats and signs of division

among Republicans.

The survey by the Associated Press-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research arrives at a moment when a once-consensus foreign policy issue is increasingly polarizing Americans along partisan and generational lines, driven by criticism for Israel's conduct nearly three years after the outbreak of

its latest war with Hamas in Gaza.

About one-third of U.S. adults — including roughly half of Democrats — believe that Israel has committed genocide against Palestinians during the war in Gaza, an accusation that has been leveled by some human rights organizations and vehemently denied by Israel

and the U.S. government. About 2 in 10 Americans say Israel has not and the rest, about half, don't know enough to say.

A similar share, 30%, of Jewish adults say Israel has committed genocide, although about half, 49%, say it has not.

Harold Kalmus, a 69- [See Poll, A6]

# A taco empire, a charred body and ICE

Immigration enforcement complicates a grim murder case in L.A.

By James Queally and Brittney Mejia



GINA FERRAZZI/Los Angeles Times

**RICOS TACOS NAOMI** began in 2018, and it grew to nearly a dozen locations across the Southland.

Mariana Yepez climbed the ranks of the Los Angeles street food scene before building her own taco empire.

A native of Sonora, Mexico, Yepez and her husband toiled at various food trucks and restaurants until 2018, when they launched a series of stands named after their daughter: Ricos Tacos Naomi.

Serving up heaps of fatty cabeza and sizzling al pastor, it grew to nearly a dozen locations spanning from Long Beach to L.A. to the Antelope Valley, drawing

praise from prominent food critics.

But now, Yepez sits in jail — accused of plotting to kill one of her employees.

Yepez, 43, and a worker at Ricos Tacos Naomi are charged with conspiracy to commit murder in the death of Soledad Lopez, who was last seen alive around 2 p.m. on Sept. 7. A second employee faces murder charges.

Video surveillance showed the 47-year-old Lopez leaving work at one of the taco stands with her co-worker, Sandra Romo Diaz. [See Killing, A7]

# DMV threatens to revoke licenses, cites mysterious testing 'anomalies'

By CLARA HARTER

Thousands of Californians have received letters from the Department of Motor Vehicles informing them that irregularities were found in their written test results and that they will lose their licenses unless they retake the exam within 30 days.

The letters have left many Californians scratching their heads as to what went wrong and scrambling to reschedule their tests to

ensure they don't lose the ability to drive.

"It's a major headache for people who maybe don't have reliable transportation," Sacramento resident David Specht said. "A single parent raising a kid, they have to take time off work, they have to get child care. It just seems like if that's our system, it isn't really working for us."

A spokesperson for the DMV wrote in an email that the agency had "identified anomalies in the results of certain knowledge tests"

and that as a result about 11,000 people are being notified that they must retake the exam.

The spokesperson said the letters were a result of the DMV's regular internal monitoring process, and did not respond to questions on the nature of the irregularities detected — such as whether they were suspected to be evidence of cheating or the result of internal technical problems.

"Ensuring the integrity of our testing process is essential [See DMV, A8]

## Slew of crimes linked to India

U.S. prosecutors say gangsters directed murders, extortion and drug trafficking from foreign jails. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

## Soarin' ride highlights beauty

Disneyland's patriotic makeover of the attraction has national parks and new smells. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

## Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 86/65. **B6**



ALLEN J. SCHABEN/Los Angeles Times

## DOWN AND OUT

The U.S. suffers a 4-1 defeat by Belgium in the World Cup round of 16, but the team hopes the tournament run inspired future stars. **SPORTS, B10**